GATHERLY

Full Product Plan

Roadmap, user journeys, system design, implementation details, QA, launch and operations

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From static client demo to a validated, privacy-conscious event invitation service.

Current stage: client-ready static presentation demo on GitHub Pages. No backend, account system, email delivery, or shared RSVP service exists. The demo remains free and uses fictional data only.

Prepared: 3 November 2026

Planning version 1.0. Prepared from the product brief, current demo scope, and confirmed product decisions.

Confirmed decisions

- Themes: preset designs with adjustable colors and fonts, photo upload/replace, and preview before publishing.
- RSVP revisions: guests may change their response and party size until the event deadline; after that, only after the host reopens responses.
- Budget: use free/local options for demo and validation. No paid hosting or service without explicit approval.
- Priority: client self-exploration first; live walkthrough is a secondary presentation mode.

1. Executive summary

Gatherly is a web-based invitation and guest-management concept for hosts planning birthdays, weddings, christenings, family gatherings, and other celebrations. The product promise is one attractive invitation link and one place to manage guest responses and event updates. Guests should view the invitation and RSVP without creating a host account.

The current project is a static HTML/CSS/JavaScript demo. Its fictional guests and RSVP responses are stored in the same browser and are not sent to a host or synchronized across visitors. GitHub Pages is suitable for presenting that prototype, not for real guest records, private RSVP storage, accounts, or email delivery.

Plan principle: validate the idea at no cost first. Build the real service only after the audience, access model, privacy decisions, launch region, costs, and pilot scope are approved.

Success means

- Hosts create and publish an event without assistance; invited guests complete an account-free RSVP.
- Hosts accurately manage guests, see current response totals, send controlled updates, and export the final list.
- Theme customization is understandable, readable, and retained on the published invitation.
- RSVP revisions obey deadline/reopen policy and do not duplicate records.
- Pilot evidence validates customer value and willingness to pay before ongoing costs are accepted.

Scope boundary

MVP direction	Decision-gated or later
Host account and event dashboard; setup; preset theme with color/font/photo customization; preview and publish; guest list; account-free RSVP; deadline/reopen; dashboard totals; email-first updates/reminders; export.	Optional co-hosts, private links, custom questions/notes/dietary fields; payments/ticketing; seating; vendors; complex multi-day agendas; custom domains; native apps; SMS/WhatsApp.

2. Current baseline and guardrails

Current demo

- Static landing page and interactive host dashboard preview for one fictional event.
- Guest search/filter, sample guest addition, guest invitation screen, RSVP form, and local RSVP-to-dashboard walkthrough.
- localStorage makes the walkthrough persist in the same browser and site origin; a reset clears demo state.
- Share invite shares the static invitation URL only; it does not send an invitation or carry private RSVP data.
- GitHub Pages is enabled for public demo hosting; repository and published content must be treated as public.

Non-negotiable boundaries

- Never use real guest names, contact details, dietary/health information, private event details, or private photographs in the public static demo.
- Do not describe a locally stored RSVP as a response received by a host.
- Do not put credentials, backend secrets, service keys, or production guest exports in frontend code or a public repository.
- The eventual product must use a trusted backend for authorization, shared persistence, deadline enforcement, and email delivery.
- Free tiers can change; zero-cost production operation is not guaranteed. Paid services require explicit approval.

Roadmap phases are gates, not calendar promises. Estimate duration and staffing after requirements, target region, pilot size, and service choices are known. Guest identity, access, retention, and privacy decisions must precede dependent data-model implementation.

3. End-to-end user journeys

Host: create and publish

- Create a host account and open the event dashboard.
- Start an event; enter title, description, local date/time, event time zone, venue, schedule, RSVP deadline, and response-open state.
- Choose a preset invitation theme; adjust allowed colors/fonts; add or replace a photo; inspect live preview and accessibility/readability feedback.
- Add guests individually or import a supported list; organize groups; define party-size limits and any approved RSVP questions.
- Preview desktop/mobile invitation; confirm exactly which event details are public.
- Publish; create public event URL and guest-specific RSVP access for each invitee; share by approved channels.
- Monitor invited/attending/declined/awaiting totals and guest list; search/filter; correct records; reopen responses if needed.
- Preview recipients and message content before sending updates/reminders; inspect delivery results.
- Export authorized guest/RSVP data; close or delete the event under the retention policy.

Guest: view, reply, revise

- Open the invitation on mobile or desktop; see published event details, not other guests or host-only notes.
- Respond without creating a host account: attending, declined, or undecided; set party size within the invitation limit.
- See confirmation of the saved response and how to revise it.
- Before deadline, reopen authorized access and change reply/party size; update one response rather than create a duplicate.
- After deadline, show a closed state and host contact path. When host reopens, allow an authorized guest to revise again.
- For expired, revoked, or invalid guest links, deny access without exposing whether another guest exists.

Host reopens responses

Host explicitly reopens responses. The service records who reopened the event and when. Product requirements must decide if reopening is indefinite, manually closed, or has a new close time. The invitation shows live state, and the server enforces it for every RSVP write.

4. System architecture and trust boundaries

Planning-level component map. Provider choice is deferred until validation, region/privacy review, and cost comparison.

Component	Responsibility	Trust boundary
Host web app	Event setup, theme editor, guest management, dashboard, exports, message preview/send UX.	Browser is untrusted; never authorize using client-supplied owner IDs.
Guest web app	Render published fields; submit/update one guest RSVP through scoped guest access.	Public view reveals approved details only; access scopes to one guest/household.
Application API	Authentication, authorization, event/guest operations, RSVP rules, upload validation, email orchestration.	Authoritative business rules and server-side validation live here.
Relational database	Tenant-scoped hosts, memberships, events, guests, current RSVP, designs, questions, messages.	Private; enforce constraints and tenant access checks.
Object storage	Invitation photos, private by default, validated access and deletion.	Private keys; validate actual media type/size; strip unnecessary metadata.
Email provider	Transactional event invitations/updates/reminders and delivery events.	Separate credentials; recipient preview; rate limits and bounce handling.

The static demo stays isolated from the real service. GitHub Pages can host a frontend calling a secure backend, but it cannot itself provide server-side privacy or authorization.

Request/data flow

Host browser -> HTTPS API -> authorization/validation -> database and private photo storage

Guest browser -> published invitation fields -> scoped guest access -> RSVP API -> one transactional current response

Host dashboard reads current responses -> computed totals; email preview -> explicit send -> queue/outbox -> provider -> delivery status

Technical direction to evaluate

- Static frontend plus server-side API/functions and managed relational database is a low-operations candidate; compare options rather than selecting on free-tier headline alone.
- Use an established host-auth provider; avoid custom password handling for an MVP.
- Keep database, file storage, email and hosting provider choices behind practical interfaces to support export/migration.
- Store event IANA time zone; run stateful API close to selected database region.
- No production service/vendor is selected by this plan; regional/privacy and pricing review remain approval gates.

5. Domain model and ownership

Entity	Core fields / relationship	Rule
Host account	Identity, verified email, status, timestamps.	Authenticated identity scopes every host operation.
Event	Owner, details, local date/time + IANA zone, venue/schedule, deadline, response/publish state, public ID.	Only published fields are guest-visible.
Event membership	Event, host user, role, accepted/revoked timestamps.	Optional co-host; role is event-scoped; revocation takes effect promptly.
Invitation design	Event, preset/version, allowed color/font keys, photo asset reference.	Whitelist choices; theme cannot lose details or RSVP controls.
Guest/invitee	Event, name, group, contact if required, party maximum, status.	Minimize data; decide individual versus household first.
Guest access grant	Guest/household, token hash, issue/expiry/revocation.	Scoped, high entropy, revocable; token is a secret and must not be logged.
RSVP	One current response per guest, status, party size, answers, timestamps.	Revisions update in place; unanswered differs from maybe.
Question/answer	Event-defined schema and validated guest response.	Optional; constrain type/length and disclose answer visibility.
Message/delivery	Recipients, preview version, send status, provider reference/failure.	Explicit send; idempotent retry; minimize retained body.
Photo asset	Event, storage key, media type, dimensions/size, deletion state.	Private storage; validate and delete under event policy.

Count definitions

- Invited means invitee records; attending headcount is the sum of current attending party sizes.
- Awaiting is no submitted response; undecided is a submitted maybe and should be counted distinctly or explicitly grouped.
- Declined party size must not inflate attendance. Decide how party size is handled for maybe/no.
- Calculate totals from current records or use transactionally maintained aggregates with consistency checks.

Tenant and guest ownership

Every event-owned row carries an event scope. Every host read, update, import, export and delete is checked against current ownership/membership. Guest APIs resolve identity through a scoped grant; a caller cannot choose an arbitrary guest ID and gain access.

6. API and backend workflow outline

Use HTTPS and a versioned API. Exact framework, hosting, schemas, and URL patterns remain implementation decisions.

Capability	Representative operations	Authorization
Host identity	Current profile; sign-in/out and verification via selected provider.	Authenticated host session.
Events	Create/list/get/update/delete; publish/unpublish/close; reopen/close responses.	Owner or authorized member; scope every query.
Design	List presets; save design options; upload/finalize/remove photo; preview.	Host membership; upload limits and ownership.
Guests	List/add/get/update/remove; groups; import validation; export.	Host membership; exports scoped.
Public invite	Read published invitation by public identifier.	Published fields only; no guest list or RSVP totals by default.
Guest access	Exchange unique token for scoped session; read own invite/response.	Guest grant only; revocable; no arbitrary guest IDs.
RSVP	Create or replace current response; party size and approved answers.	Scoped guest session; server checks deadline/reopen.
Messages	Preview recipients/content; explicit send; list delivery status.	Host membership; consent/rate checks; idempotency.
Dashboard	Event summary and paginated guest list.	Host membership; filters never bypass tenant scope.

Transactional RSVP write

- Resolve scoped guest grant and validate event/grant state.
- Within the write transaction, verify response state using server time and configured time-zone rules.
- Validate yes/no/maybe, party size <= allowed maximum, and any enabled question answers.
- Insert first response or update that guest's current response; never create a second RSVP on revision.
- Record version/timestamps; return latest saved response and confirmation.
- Recheck deadline/reopen state in the transaction to prevent a race with host closure.

Email send workflow

- Host selects recipients and drafts an update/reminder; server previews eligible/suppressed recipients and exact content.
- Host confirms recipient list/content; server records intent in an outbox transaction.
- Worker sends with idempotency/retry limits; provider callbacks update accepted/bounced/failed state.
- Host sees outcomes and recovers failures; provider acceptance is not equivalent to inbox delivery.

7. Functional requirements by product area

Host workspace and event lifecycle

- Host account, multiple-event dashboard, and event-level data separation.
- Event fields: title, description, local date/time, IANA time zone, venue/address, schedule as needed, RSVP deadline.
- Distinguish draft, published, closed, and deleted/archived states; host explicitly chooses when edits become public.
- Define if published changes notify guests.

Themes, photo and publication

- Curated responsive presets; fixed layout structures and accessible controls initially.
- Allow palette/font selection and photo upload/replace; approve formats, size/dimension limits, crop behavior, photo rights and deletion.
- Preview draft/published state; preserve event fields and RSVP controls across theme changes.
- Provide contrast/readability warnings or safe fallback; publish shareable event URL.
- Define public/unlisted/private behavior; a hard-to-guess URL alone is not authorization.

Guest management

- Add, group, search, edit, remove; set response status and party-size limit.
- Import with field mapping preview, duplicate detection, validation, row errors, file limits and safe retries.
- Export approved event fields in a portable format; protect downloads and logs.
- Decide individual versus household model before import, plus-ones, tokens, counts and exports.

Guest invitation and RSVP

- Account-free guest flow with mobile-readable event page and accessible form.
- Responses: attending, declined, undecided; unanswered is separate from undecided.
- Enforce party-size maximum; define party semantics for maybe/no and named plus-ones.
- Allow revisions up to deadline; after deadline block unless host reopens; server remains source of truth.
- Guest sees only own response; public event URL never exposes private guest details.

7. Functional requirements (continued)

Updates and reminders

- Email is initial channel. Host selects audience and previews recipients, message, event details and link before send.
- Start with event update and RSVP reminder templates; manual send first. Schedule only if validated and explicitly scoped.
- Track queued/accepted/bounced/failed/suppressed where provider supports; retry transient failures safely.
- Configure sender authentication, consent/unsubscribe, bounce suppression and limits for launch region/message type.
- Automated SMS/WhatsApp is deferred and not an MVP dependency.

Optional co-hosts and questions

- Co-host access is decision-gated: specify invitation, event-scoped roles, permissions, revocation and audit history.
- Custom questions, guest notes and dietary needs are optional; collect only if needed and disclose visibility/retention.
- Avoid sensitive details without clear product purpose, access and retention decisions.

Export, closure and deletion

- Host exports event guest and response data in a defined format with agreed fields/timestamps.
- Host can close responses, close or delete event; define behavior of guest links, photos, exports, backups and retention.
- Communicate backup retention accurately and test deletion workflow.

Pricing hypothesis

- Hypothesis: free draft/preview and one-time fee to publish; upgrades only after learning value and costs.
- No payment checkout until willingness-to-pay and operating costs are validated.
- Do not commit to limits or fixed pricing before modeling hosting, storage, email, support and payment costs.

8. Roadmap and phase gates

Owners are proposed roles, not a staffing promise. Thresholds are recommendations to approve before execution.

Phase / owner	Work and deliverables	Exit gate / dependency
0. Demo + discovery / EM, Product, Frontend	Maintain fictional static demo. Observe self-guided client use/live walkthrough. Interview hosts across event types; record confusion, value, willingness-to-pay and pilot interest.	12 host interviews across 3 event types; findings recorded; 5 pilot prospects or a documented pivot. No real guest data.
1. Requirements / EM, Product, Backend, QA	PRD, user stories, role matrix, data inventory, guest/household model, RSVP rules, link visibility, retention/deletion, region and support scope.	Every core flow has acceptance criteria; no blocking access, identity, deadline, email-data or privacy decisions.
2. UX validation / Frontend, QA, Product	Host/guest/error/empty/expired/closed flows; event setup, theme editor, preview, mobile views, dashboard and message preview.	5 hosts and 5 guests test; 4/5 in each group complete primary task unaided; keyboard/deadline states reviewed.
3. Architecture/cost gate / Backend, DevOps, EM	Compare API/database/auth/storage/email; map threat model, region, export/migration, free limits and cost triggers; schemas, API, ops/recovery.	Approved region/privacy and cost ceiling; provider terms and exit plan documented; no paid commitment without approval.
4. Build/integration / Backend, Frontend; QA/DevOps	Vertical slices: account/event -> design/publish -> guest access/operations -> RSVP lifecycle -> dashboard/export -> messages -> optional scope.	Acceptance suite, tenant/guest access, deadline/reopen, accessibility/browser gates pass; no unresolved critical/high defects.
5. Private pilot / Product/EM + all roles	5-10 consented real events in approved region; limited size; support, monitoring, backups, incident response and data cleanup.	>=80% hosts create/publish unaided; zero cross-event exposure; no unresolved critical defect; email/recovery understood.
6. Release decision / EM; QA, DevOps, Product	Fix pilot issues; finalize help, privacy/retention, terms, rollback/restore, sender setup and operational ownership.	Release blockers resolved; restore/rollback exercised; region/email policy reviewed; expected cost approved.
7. Operate/iterate / Product, DevOps, Backend, QA	Review availability/errors, email, privacy incidents, support, adoption and cost; exercise restore/deletion; evidence-led roadmap.	Monthly review and documented incident, recovery and deletion owners.

9. Implementation sequence

Slice	Implementation detail	Ready when
1. Identity/tenant base	Host auth integration; host profile; event owner/membership schema; authorization policies; audit critical access changes.	Two hosts cannot read or modify each other's data.
2. Event lifecycle	Draft, details/date/time zone, edit, close, publish, public identifier and owner controls.	Host publishes minimal event; only intended fields are public.
3. Theme/photo	Preset gallery; allowed colors/fonts; upload/replace/preview; image validation/storage; accessible contrast; design publish.	Upload/rights/deletion/accessibility rules approved; preview persists.
4. Guest list	Add/edit/remove/search/group; party limits; CSV preview, validation, row errors and export.	Guest identity semantics decided; records are tenant scoped.
5. Guest access/RSVP	Scoped guest grants; public invite; submit/replace response; party size; deadline/reopen; accurate totals.	Token strategy and time-zone policy approved; transaction tests pass.
6. Summary/email	Response totals; selection and preview; send queue/outbox; provider events/retries.	Consent, sender domain, provider limits/cost and monitoring approved.
7. Pilot hardening	Security/accessibility/mobile; backups/restore; rate limits; support; retention; pilot onboarding and rollback.	No critical/high blocker; budget, privacy, incident and support owners accepted.

Vertical-slice definition

A capability is complete only end-to-end. RSVP is not done when only the form exists: the authorized guest must submit, the server must store one current response and enforce deadline rules, and the host dashboard must reflect that saved response.

MVP exclusion rule

If a feature is not needed to create/publish an event, manage invited guests, receive/private-update RSVP, understand responses, send the initial email update/reminder, or export the result, defer it unless discovery proves it is essential to the pilot.

10. Security, privacy and reliability

Guest access and authorization

- Recommended starting point: unique, high-entropy, revocable access grant per invitee; decide individual versus household before implementation.
- Keep public event URL separate from the credential authorizing RSVP edits. Never put names, emails or RSVP details in share URLs.
- Store only token hashes; rotate/revoke; avoid analytics/log/referrer leakage; use scoped session protections where appropriate.
- Guest page reads published details and its own response only; it cannot enumerate invitees or responses.
- Server checks every read/write/export/delete. IDs are not permission. Re-test after co-host changes/revocation.

Data minimization/lifecycle

- Define purpose, visibility, retention, export, closure/deletion, backup expiry and support access for every personal-data field before pilot.
- Collect contact email only when required; dietary/health details only with approved purpose and disclosure.
- Treat photos as private until deliberately published; validate type/size; use random keys; strip metadata; delete with event under policy.
- Do not log credentials, full notes, dietary answers, message bodies or guest exports; use request IDs for support.

Integrity/reliability

- Database constraints enforce one current RSVP per invitee and unique event membership.
- RSVP and answers update atomically; counts reflect latest answer; concurrent changes use version checks or equivalent.
- Server enforces event-zone deadline; define exact cutoff and daylight-saving behavior.
- Email uses transactional outbox/idempotency; explicit host confirmation; bounded retry and bounce suppression.
- Rate-limit public/token endpoints; audit host access changes, reopening, sends, exports and deletion.

11. QA strategy and release gates

Test layers

- Acceptance tests for host, guest, optional co-host, theme, deadline/reopen, import/export, deletion and messaging.
- Unit tests: validation, totals, timezone/deadline transitions, permissions, theme configuration, token expiry/revocation.
- API/integration: auth, tenant isolation, constraints, uploads, outbox, provider failure, import/export.
- End-to-end: publish, guest RSVP/revise, deadline close/reopen, dashboard, message preview/send, export/delete.
- Regression/exploratory: repeated submissions, invalid/revoked links, concurrent updates, network interruption, malformed imports.
- Accessibility/device: keyboard, screen reader, contrast, zoom/reflow, phones/tablet and agreed browser matrix.
- Privacy/security: authorized tests only; guest enumeration, token lifecycle, deletion and export boundaries.

Area	Proposed measurable gate
Usability	With >=8 hosts and >=12 guests, >=80% complete core task unaided; >=90% guest RSVP within 2 minutes; zero core blockers.
Accessibility	Target WCAG 2.2 AA in core flows; keyboard operable; text contrast >=4.5:1 normal and >=3:1 large/controls; reflow at 320 CSS px and 200% zoom; manual review.
Mobile	320/360/390px phones and tablet; current iOS Safari and Android Chrome; no clipped core content or unintended horizontal scrolling.
Privacy/security	100% documented unauthorized-access tests denied; zero cross-tenant exposure/modification; no Critical/High privacy defects.
Data integrity	Retries yield one current response; totals reconcile; deadline boundary/reopen tests pass.
Email	Staging mail sink captures correct recipient/content/link; retries do not duplicate sends; failures visible.
Release blockers	No Critical/High defects in core workflows, authorization, privacy or integrity; critical regression suite passes.

Prototype versus product evidence

The static demo validates comprehension and interaction only. localStorage does not prove shared persistence, authorization, email or multi-user behavior. Test the prototype with synthetic names and separate browser profiles.

12. Environments, delivery and cost policy

Stage 0: current free demo

- Keep HTML/CSS/JavaScript static on GitHub Pages; local browser tests are free.
- Treat repository/site as public; inspect assets for personal data/secrets before every release.
- Use local syntax, link, responsive, browser and accessibility checks; preserve known-good Git revision/reset flow.
- No real event operation or guest data on Pages; no production promises or user accounts.

Environment	Purpose	Data/mail policy
Local	Feature development, local DB/API or disposable services.	Synthetic seed; local mail sink; no production credentials.
Preview	Review proposed changes.	Isolated synthetic data; emails intercepted; no production connection.
Staging	Release candidate integration/rehearsal.	Separate auth/database/secrets; synthetic accounts; mail sandbox.
Pilot/production	Real, consented events in one approved region.	Restricted access, least privilege, retention, backups, alerts and incident owner.

CI/CD and release

- PR: formatting/lint, unit/integration/authorization tests, dependency review, accessibility checks, preview deploy.
- Preview cannot send real mail or access production data; merge to staging; production promotion needs explicit approval.
- Use reviewed versioned backward-compatible database migrations; deploy in safe expand/migrate/contract sequence.
- Post-deploy smoke checks. App rollback is separate from database restore; database rollback is planned, not automatic.

12. Environments, delivery and cost policy (continued)

Future services: evaluate, do not assume

Managed services can reduce operating burden, but free-tier quotas, regions, pause behavior, backups, email limits, legal terms and billing rules must be rechecked at selection and before launch. Compare hosted database/auth/storage, static/serverless hosting and transactional email options. No provider or free tier is guaranteed by this plan.

Budget and approval rules

- No paid hosting, custom domain, email plan, storage or recurring service without explicit approval.
- Before a real pilot, estimate cost at expected event/guest/photo/email volume; document quotas, alerts, suspension/failure consequences, export and migration.
- Approve launch region, data obligations, sender domain, backup, incident response and operator before real data.
- Cost triggers include missing reliable backup/restore, likely quota exhaustion, paid email requirements, or production support/security needs beyond free commitments.
- A free tier is not a permanent zero-cost guarantee, SLA or backup guarantee.

Secrets, recovery and monitoring

- Store secrets in encrypted secret manager; unique credentials per environment; least privilege.
- Define recovery point/time objectives, retention, restore authority, deletion behavior and incident contact; test restore before pilot and periodically.
- Monitor API errors/latency, database pressure, storage, backup failures, email bounces/complaints and security events without sensitive payload logs.
- Write runbooks for exposure, token leak, provider outage, failed email, event deletion and cost-limit breach.

13. Risks, assumptions and open decisions

Risk / question	Why it matters	Action
Individual or household guest?	Token scope, party size, imports, counts and exports.	Decide in PRD before schema; Product/EM.
Guest access grants	Public event link must not authorize another RSVP.	Choose scoped revocable links; threat model and test.
Deadline semantics	Time zone, exact cutoff, maybe/party count, reopening expiry.	Specify event-zone rule and boundary tests.
Public versus unlisted invite	Unlisted URL is not authentication; details may be sensitive.	Define public fields and access policy.
Contact data/email consent	Delivery and regional compliance/deliverability.	Define required fields, consent and unsubscribe.
Photo upload/rights	Privacy, file safety, cost and third-party rights.	Approve limits, validation, consent and deletion.
Co-host permissions	Unauthorized event/guest access risk.	Define roles/revocation; defer if not pilot-essential.
Free tier reliability	Limits, suspension, charges, backup uncertainty.	Caps, alerts, export/migration; approve spend.
Global launch	Data location, locale and privacy obligations vary.	Choose one pilot region/language first.
Scope expansion	Adds cost, schedule and compliance burden.	Freeze MVP; defer without evidence/approval.

Assumptions to validate

- Hosts value reduced invitation/RSVP coordination enough to use/pay for a focused product.
- Guests accept simple account-free RSVP; secure guest-specific revision access remains usable.
- Pilot can focus on one manageable region and a few event types while the design remains expansion-ready.
- Email-first messaging is sufficient; SMS/WhatsApp are not launch dependencies.
- Pay-per-event is a hypothesis, not a fixed price or implemented checkout.

14. Success measures and operating cadence

Measure	Definition/evidence	Review
Host activation	Creates and publishes without help; time-to-publish and abandonment.	Usability/pilot weekly.
Guest RSVP completion	Eligible invitees responding; completion time/device.	Per event and pilot weekly.
Response management	Host returns, manages guests, handles revisions and totals.	Pilot/monthly.
Theme usefulness	Host chooses/customizes/previews; accessibility issues and abandonment.	Design test/pilot.
Email outcome	Acceptance, bounce, complaint, retry/failure; acceptance != inbox delivery.	Pilot weekly/incidents.
Customer evidence	Value, willingness-to-pay, event type and priority evidence.	After each research/pilot cohort.
Reliability/privacy	Errors, recovery, support incidents, auth tests and exposure.	Monthly/incident immediately.
Cost per event	Hosting/database/storage/email/support under observed sizes.	Before pilot/monthly.

Pilot review

- Compare observed journeys to acceptance criteria; document pass/fail evidence and support load.
- Interview hosts and sample guests after completion; identify trust, access, RSVP and theme friction.
- Review event cost and quotas before expanding volume or region.
- Choose continue, revise, price-test, secure budget or stop. Signup count alone is not product success.

Weekly in active pilot: defects, access/email failures, usability feedback and cost/quota trend. Monthly after pilot: privacy/security events, recovery, support, adoption, email health, cost and roadmap. Immediate incident review for guest-data exposure, unauthorized RSVP change, credential leak or unrecoverable loss.

15. Deferred scope and readiness checklist

Explicitly defer from initial release

- Payments/ticketing until willingness-to-pay and costs are validated.
- Seating charts, vendor management, complex multi-day schedules, custom domains and native mobile apps.
- Automated SMS/WhatsApp until demand, consent, cost and regional rules are reviewed.
- Arbitrary layout/CSS editor and unrestricted font uploads; start with preset layouts and controlled color/font/photo customization.
- Large-scale global launch/multi-region writes until traffic, latency or residency requirements justify complexity.

Before real product work or data

- Complete user/problem validation; confirm host segment, event type and pilot region.
- Approve PRD; resolve individual-versus-household identity and guest access mechanism.
- Specify public fields, contact-data needs, consent, deadline/reopen semantics, event deletion and retention.
- Review region/legal/privacy obligations, photo rights, email policy, support and incident owner.
- Compare architecture/provider terms/free limits, backups/recovery, deliverability, migration and cost.
- Approve any paid service explicitly before billing or real guest data.
- Prove server-side access boundaries before inviting real users.

Definition of done for the first real pilot

- Host can create, customize, preview, publish and manage event/guest list.
- Authorized account-free guest sees public details and their own response; can revise before deadline and is blocked after close unless host reopens.
- Dashboard totals reconcile; email is previewed, explicitly confirmed, safely delivered/tracked; export is protected.
- Privacy, access, accessibility, mobile, recovery, support, cost and release gates have evidence; no Critical/High blocker.
- Small consented pilot has approved region, operator, spend ceiling, deletion policy and rollback/recovery path.

This document is a planning baseline, not a build commitment. Product scope, privacy/legal requirements, provider pricing/terms, region, and implementation estimates must be validated before production work.

Source context: Event Invitation Platform Product Plan (November 2026); current Gatherly static demo and README; confirmed product-owner choices on theme customization, RSVP change deadline, free-first hosting, and client self-exploration. Role contributions from Engineering Management, Backend, QA and DevOps are consolidated as planning recommendations.

Appendix A. Requirement traceability

Product promise	Plan section	Proof before release
Polished invitation and shareable link	3, 7, implementation slices 2-3	Theme preview/publish E2E; link shows published fields only.
Host guest operations	5-7	CRUD/import/export authorization and integrity tests.
Account-free guest RSVP	3, 6-7	Guest responds without host account; own response only.
Revision until deadline/reopen	3, 6, 10	Server time-zone boundary tests; one current response.
Preset themes + colors/fonts/photo	7, implementation slice 3	Accessible preview; upload validation; persistence/deletion.
Email updates/reminders	6-7, implementation slice 6	Preview, selected recipients, idempotent delivery status.
Privacy and host control	4-5, 10-12	Tenant isolation, scoped grants, closure/revocation/deletion.
Pay-per-event hypothesis	7, 14	Customer evidence and cost estimate; checkout not required yet.
Global-ready staged launch	3, 10, 13	Timezone-aware storage, initial region/legal review, locale checks.

Appendix B. Proposed first backlog epics

Epic	User outcome	Dependency
Product decisions	Approved guest model, access, deadline, public fields, region and retention.	Discovery
Account/workspace	Host sees only their own events.	Architecture/auth
Event setup	Host enters event details, time zone and response deadline.	PRD
Invitation design	Select preset, customize colors/fonts/photo, preview.	Storage/design rules
Guest operations	Add/group/search/edit/import/export guests.	Guest identity semantics
Invitation/RSVP	Account-free, scoped response; revise, deadline/reopen.	Access grants
Dashboard	Accurate totals/latest response.	RSVP integrity
Email communications	Preview, select audience, send, inspect result.	Consent/provider/domain/cost
Pilot operations	Support, backups, deletion, alerts, cost limits, rollback.	All MVP slices